frustration among aspirants protesting in Srinagar and Jammu are palpable, and not without reason. In the absence of a robust private sector in J&K—mainly due to years of violence—the government sector is the biggest employer, with about 450,000 people on its rolls. Nearly 100,000 candidates appeared for the 1,200 posts of SI last year.

L-G SINHA MAINTAINS TRANSPARENCY IS GOVT'S TOP PRIORITY AND THERE WON'T BE ANY COMPROMISE ON MERIT

JKSSB chairman Rajesh Sharma claims the protesters have "ulterior motives" and that Aptech was hired after following the prescribed rules. "Nine companies participated in the bidding process, and sought an amendment [to the criteria] during deliberations in a pre-bid meeting," he says. Legally, he adds, there was no reason to debar Aptech. Senior advocate Abhinav Sharma, who is representing Aptech in the high court, explains the firm had approached the JKSSB before bidding to highlight a 2014 Supreme Court ruling that stated no firm can be debarred from participating in the process after the period for its blacklisting was over.

The justifications notwithstanding, the future of thousands of job aspirants is on the line, and they want a complete revamp of the recruitment board to ensure transparency and accountability. "We are determined to get justice after having lost our precious time and resources," says Vinkal Sharma, who is leading the struggle in the high court as well as on the streets in Jammu. Amid the rising tempers and a flurry of allegations, the judiciary and the L-G have their work cut out. And that is to ensure that everything's above board. ■



ANI

THE WAR BEGINS
Telangana BJP chief 'Bandi' Sanjay being arrested

TELANGANA

SAFFRON SCALE-UP

By Amarnath K. Menon

Telangana BJP president 'Bandi' Sanjay is seldom hesitant to take on Chief Minister K. Chandrashekar Rao. On April 7, he dared KCR to order a judicial inquiry by a sitting high court judge into the alleged circulation of the Hindi question papers of the current Secondary School Certificate (SSC) examinations on a messaging app, if he genuinely wanted to bring the real culprits to justice.

The dare came from Sanjay soon after he was released on bail, following a court order. He was arrested on April 6. Earlier, while in prison, he wrote a letter to the BJP cadres, stating his arrest was a conspiracy of the ruling Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS). "Arresting me and harassing the BJP workers is like throwing a ball against the ground. We shall only bounce back with the same force," he wrote.

Sanjay is tagged as accused No.1 in the SSC paper leak case—with non-bailable provisions that entail three to seven years of imprisonment. Besides Sanjay, the police named nine others as accused, including a minor boy.

The remand report stated that this was 'a case of pre-planned and evil designed criminal conspiracy', with an intention to create rumours and provoke a breach of peace, and to show it as the failure of the government in preventing the paper leak. It was intended to defame the elected government, it added. Unimpressed, the principal judicial magistrate, Hanamkonda, ordered his release on April 7. It enabled Sanjay to be at hand in welcoming Prime Minister Narendra Modi on April 8 to unveil and ground a slew of Centre-sponsored projects totalling Rs 11,500 crore.

The calculated manner in which the ruling BRS has targeted the belligerent Sanjay has prompted the BJP to continue with him as the state party chief. This is despite Eatala Rajender, an ex-KCR acolyte and influential OBC